

SAMRIDDHI KHARE

URBAN PLANNING PORTFOLIO



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PEHCHAAN: TRANSGENDER INCLUSIVITY IN INDIAN URBANISM

[NEW DELHI, 2021]

gender and sexuality, indian urbanism, public participation

1.0

Design, Execution, Research, Implementation
Leader: Group of 5

Observation Action
Network Fellowship,
2021



Transgender Art and Culture

Prejudice against transgenders in India has pushed the community into near-complete digital and physical obscurity. Often denied the right to formal education (as a consequence of harassment or gender dysphoria), a large section of the demographic pursues careers in handicraft and performing arts. However, many talented individuals from the community do not have access to a platform to demonstrate or practise their skills.

Alternative

"Pehchaan", which translates to "identity", is rooted in the fight against the invisibility of the transgender community in Delhi's public spaces. The primary motivation of Pehchaan is to affirm the trans community's right to gender identity, equality and public space. This project aims to help them build their artistic capacities and sensitize the common public to the lives of the transgender community using collaboratively designed art.

This project specifically studies Delhi's hijra community: a visually non-conforming subset of transgendered women.



1.1 Sensitization and Activity Mapping

MAHIRA LIVES IN A GURU-CHELA SYSTEM WITH A GHARANA*. MOST WOMEN IN THE CITY LIVE IN THESE SYSTEMS OF DEPENDENCIES.



8:00 AM

MAHIRA USES PUBLIC TRANSPORT TO MOVE ABOUT THE CITY.



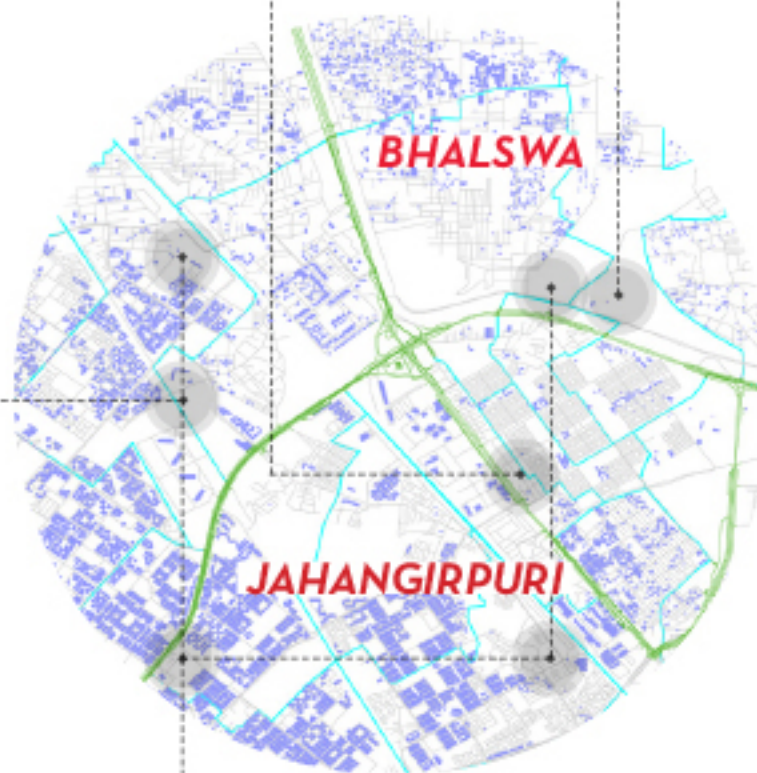
9:00 AM

ON A BUSY DAY, SHE EARNS MOST OF HER INCOME BEGGING NEAR TRAFFIC SIGNALS.



12:00 PM

major roads minor roads wards residential areas districts



Bhalswa-Jahangirpuri border, North West Delhi
(areas identified as transgender gharanas/concentrations)

To highlight the identified issues of the trans community we developed a comic series "Meet Mahira" in which the protagonist, a trans woman, takes the reader through a day in her life

Narrative described by: Mahira Qureshi
(Project Mentor, transwoman)

Accompanying activity mapping helped identify sites of intervention with respect to space utilization and proximity to stakeholders such as trans relief organisations, governmental bodies and public space organisations



Comics produced in local languages for awareness campaign

3:00 PM

IF SHE'S LUCKY, SHE'LL BE INVITED TO BLESS NEWBORNS IN A WEALTHY HOUSEHOLD.



7:00 PM

MAHIRA'S COMMUNITY HAS BEEN DISPROPORTIONATELY HIT BY THE PANDEMIC. THEY DO NOT POSSESS GOVERNMENT IDENTIFICATION WHICH PREVENTS THEM FROM AVAILING RELIEF



9:00 PM

SHE OFTEN FACES DISCRIMINATION FROM PEOPLE WHO MISUNDERSTAND HER.



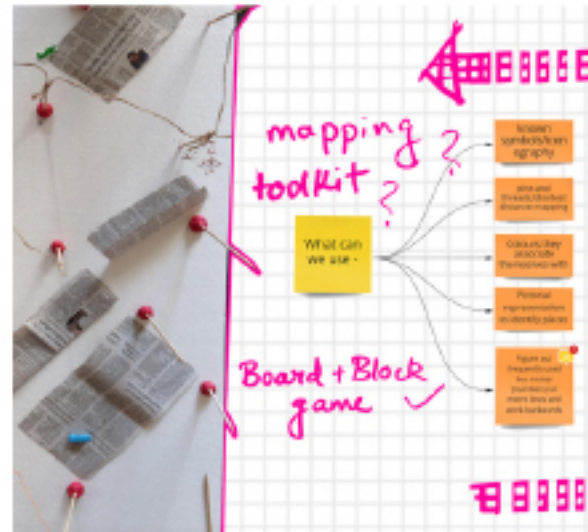
1.2 Construction of Community Engagement Timeline



1.3 Collaborative Design Exercise

Through community engagement we learnt that a large demographic within the trans community derived employment through performing arts and handicrafts. In an attempt to archive the talent of this community and create visual narratives to drive a shift in the perception, we organized a collaborative design exercise - rangmanch. (rang: colours, manch-stage)

The exercise was developed in collaboration with community representatives (majorly from the hijra/kinnar community). Prompts were assigned to participants through a game style format and they made art work to be displayed on the panels of the tableau (under construction) Their testimonials on inclusivity in the built environment were recorded and digitized.



Step 1: Preparations

Bearing in mind the limitations of education and literacy we developed contextual prompts for board and block game that facilitated the collaborative design exercise



Step 5: Testimonials

We recorded testimonials of participants directly expressing their concerns and we amplified their voices through social media



Step 2: Collaboration

We established a community presence through collaborative events - art exercises were often followed by legal and mental health camps to further incentivise the public to engage



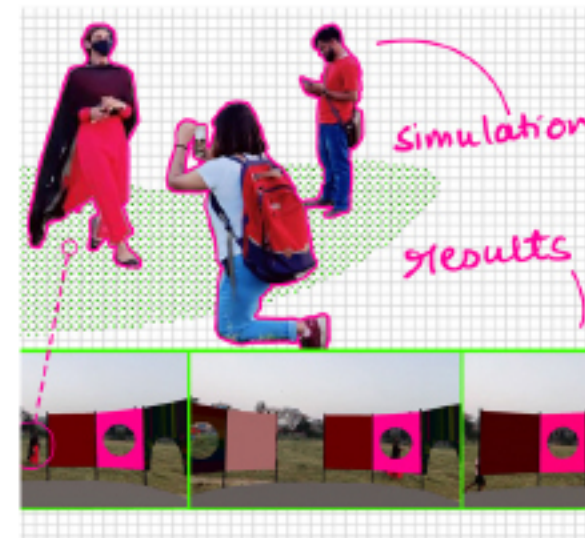
Step 6: Block Model Assembly

Participants were very proud of their finished work and shared their experience of designing the block model with us. Exceeding all expectations, they were enthusiastic about being able to express themselves creatively



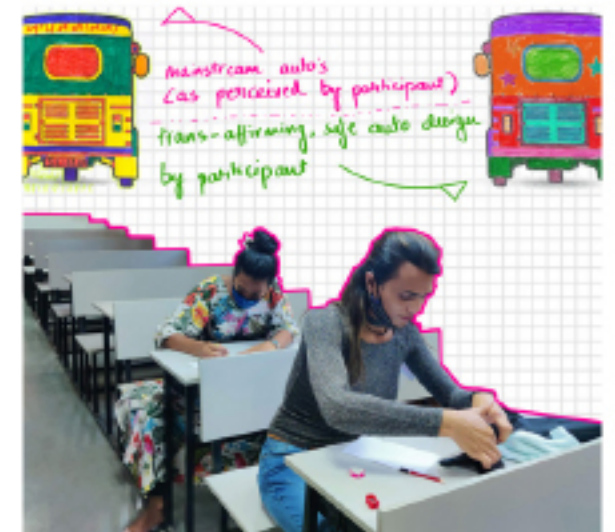
Step 3: Assignment

Participants' interests were identified and they pinned their names on the banner, under three categories: culture, society and city. Somya and Kirti spoke about discrimination in public transport, hence they were assigned a city-based prompt



Step 7: Augmented Reality Simulation

We used augmented reality overlays and experiential storytelling to show community members the potential of our design



Step 4: Exercise

Somya and Kirti were then asked to design an auto rickshaw (a motorized, three-wheeler for public hire) that they would feel safe in. They were given the tools to design, and the guidance they needed to fulfill their task



Step 8: Implementation (Ongoing)

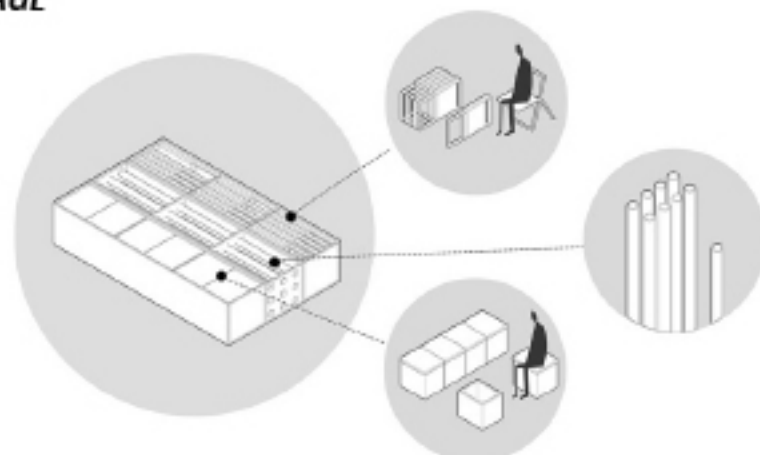
All collected artwork is being digitized, printed and displayed across New Delhi and different parts of India; fabrication of modular stage is under process

1.4 design

ASSEMBLY OF MODULAR STAGE



In-situ Placement of Stage



Stage Apparatus containing Seating, Panels and Posts



Panel depicting designs from Collab Design Exercise



Setting Stage and Posts



Connecting Panels to Posts

DESIGN CONFIGURATIONS



Stage



Mental Health Camps



Mehendi (Henna) Workshops



Exhibition



Ration Drive



Modular Configurations

All configurations have been determined through community consultation, stakeholders including trans and nontrans members expressed that they would like to utilize the design for the above functions.

DESIGN EXTENSION (ONGOING)



The artwork designed by the transgender community was positioned through public spaces (like cafes, autos and metros) through stickers and posters to represent queer affirming spaces. the design of the sticker is an amalgamation of many artworks curated and digitized from the event.

Impact

My team and I engaged with over 200 members of the transgender community through drives showcasing artwork and detailed testimonials, discovering collaborators with similar goals and finding volunteers to support and help the initiative. While working with people on-site, the team was able to expand its virtual presence on Instagram, LinkedIn and a website, amassing a total following of over 1000 passionate supporters.

With the proposal, the team promoted inclusive attitudes in people which made public spaces less hostile towards trans communities. The transgender community can identify with their city through Pehchaan.

CHITAR OLI AND THE ANALYSIS OF CASTE

[NAGPUR, 2020]

caste-based inequity analysis, housing patterns

2.0

The Urban Rhetoric,
Student Excellence Award,
2020

SURF 2020: Conference
Proceedings, BIT
Mangalore

Nagpur's Potter Slums

Chitar Oli is situated in the central-eastern part of Nagpur city of Maharashtra. The nomenclature of the slum locality is derivative of the most popular caste-based occupation of its residents – Chitaris, or sculptors, and the lane – or Oli (in the local dialect of Marathi language). This community of artisans banded together to create a more marketable product. The research explores the spatial manifestations of caste inequality, resulting in the economic marginalisation of the disadvantaged castes.

Intervention

The community reinvestment program establishes an organizational shift between producers and consumers and relates to fiscal, demographic opportunities for members of the community across caste-based, socioeconomic, and geographic lines. Repairing the communal gap between citizens of modern-day Nagpur and old neighbourhoods aims to boost revenue and has led to periodic reductions in caste-based income inequality.

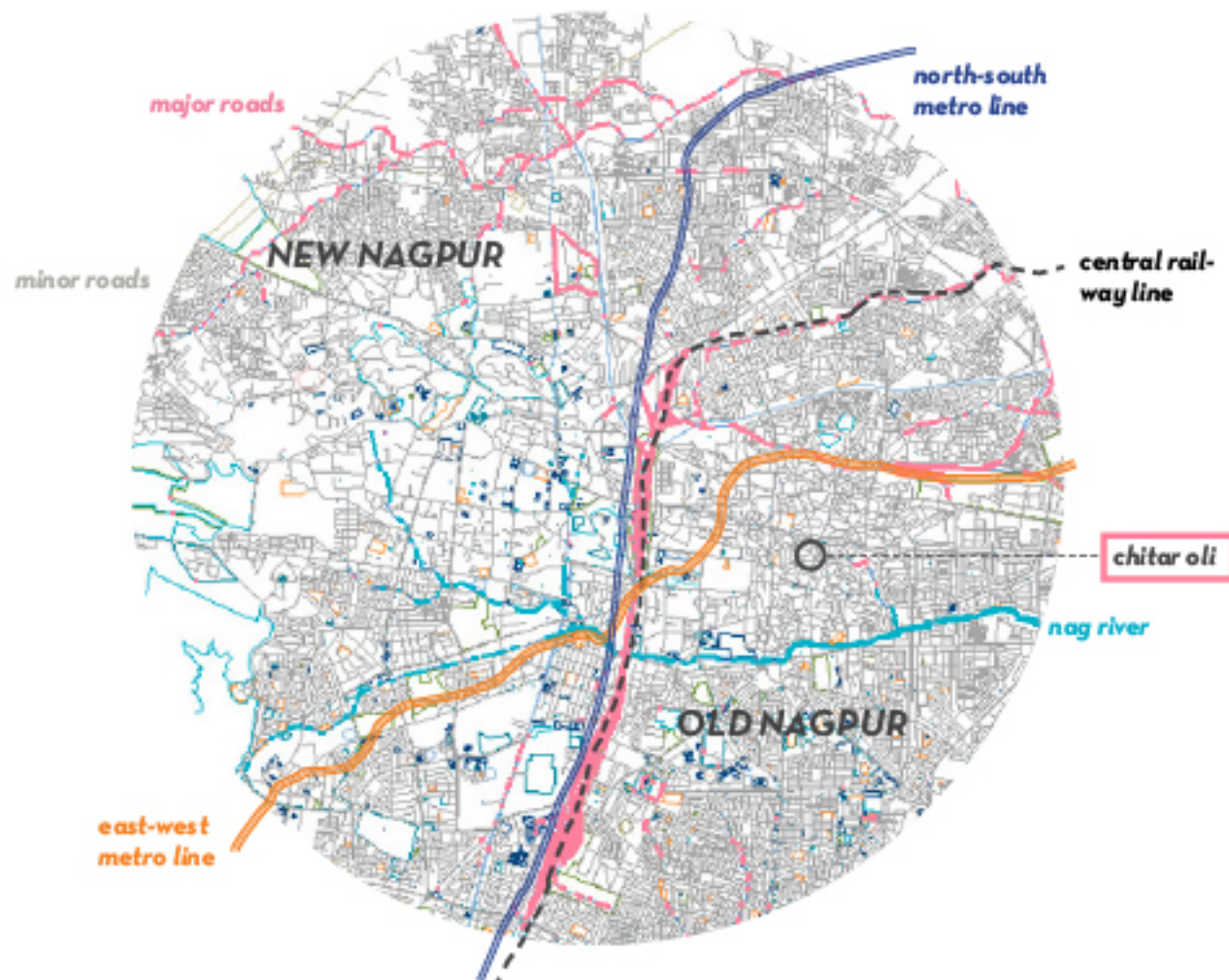


2.1 Population, Growth, Development



Nagpur's anisotropic infrastructure development has led to a steady decline in the visibility and representation of marginalized castes, limiting their access to education, employment, food and safety. The railway line of Nagpur bifurcates Nagpur into two discrete sections - east/old and west/new. Any development in the new city region, mainly residential development, is increasingly

disconnected from the historic parts of the city, including Chitar Oli. These lead to a complete collapse in the model established by the artisans. The link between the producers and consumers is driven by demand and relies heavily on consumer awareness and communication, which has been compromised due to inequitable development.

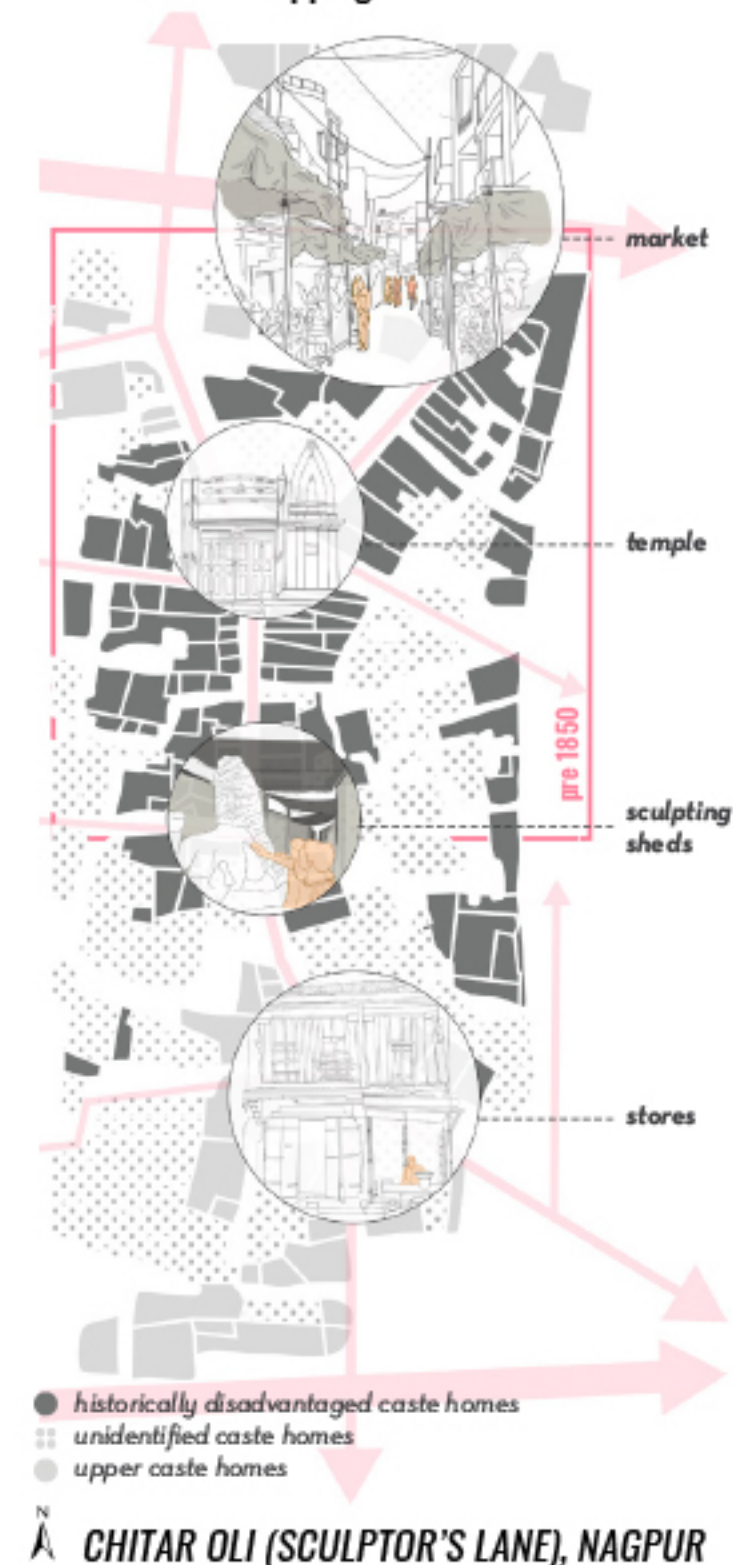


THE DEVELOPMENT OF NAGPUR

2.2 People of Chitar Oli



2.3 Functional Mapping



Chitar Oli is predominantly occupied by the chitari caste classified as Other Backwards Caste (OBC), a collective term used by the Government for socially disadvantaged castes. This socio-economic disparity manifests in the residential segregation of the neighbourhood. The congested, run-down section of the neighbourhood was occupied by members of the lower caste who

were engaged in the profession of sculpture, whereas upper-class citizens had either relocated to premium housing/lucrative jobs that were accessible exclusively to them, due to institutionalised caste privilege. We organised a neighbourhood reintegration program to establish the connection between old/new Nagpur while documenting caste-based housing inequality.

2.4 Community Reintegration Program

We organised an educational excursion to the site of Chitar Oli to sensitize the public and confer recognition and respect to members and lives of marginalised communities.



Step 1: Literature Review & Preliminary Site Visit

We studied the history and context, identified action zones and organised the research under two categories, people: artisans who were struggling with poor living conditions because of the decreased demand for their goods, and place: the synthesis of a community to make a more marketable product



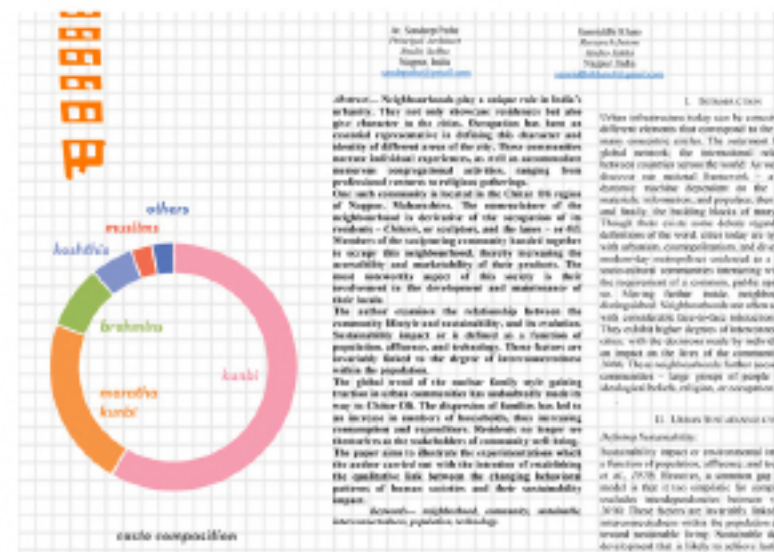
Step 4: Excursion

Visited the site with over 100 participants, stopping at strategic locations to discuss relevant heritage and socio-economic evolutions and repairing the communal gap between citizens of modern-day Nagpur and old neighbourhoods



Step 2: Organisation & Branding

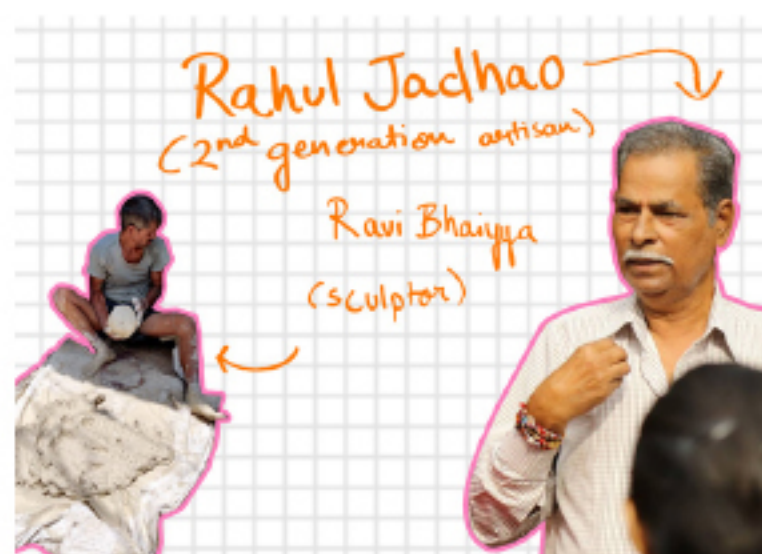
We developed a educational excursion through the neighborhood as a means to generate revenue through a "heritage dialogue". We identified key locations that would help establish the narrative of the caste-based housing inequality of the region.



Step 5: Documentation and Analysis

Documenting the current scenario, interacting with the participants and establishing a narrative to inform public perception, and validating it through photographs, publications

The tour was designed to show participants the contrasting conditions of housing within the same neighborhood, and explain (through community representatives) the history and evolution of land use and distribution in Chitar Oli over time.



Step 3: Collaboration

We constructed the tour around community representatives from low income, disadvantaged castes who wanted to share their lived experience of living in Chitar Oli with the group of citizens who wanted to learn with the community. Rahul Jadhao is a 2nd generation artisan from the community and a father of five. He shared his desire to be the last sculptor in his family due to the meagre pay and laborious nature of work.

Impact

Through the monthly community reintegration program, the citizens of Chitar Oli were able to sell their products to consumers that were previously unaware of their existence. The visit to the site initiated a cycle of mutually beneficial exchanges between the artisans and the consumers.

Funds generated through the "Cost of Admission" to the excursion were deposited into the community banking system of Chitar Oli. Garnering a crowd of over 100 participants, this substantial revenue went towards the development of the market space within Chitar Oli.

Our research was picked up by The Urban Rhetoric Magazine and the SURF: 2020 Conference at BIT Mangalore, for bringing academic attention to the issue of caste-based housing inequality.

REFORM JUSTICE NETWORK

[NEW DELHI, 2021]

prison reform, geostatistical analysis, community intervention

3.0

The Urban Rhetoric,
Student Feature,
2021

India's Justice System

Overcrowding, prolonged detention of undertrial prisoners, unsatisfactory living conditions, custodial deaths, lack of treatment programmes and allegations of inhuman approach of prison staff have repeatedly been reported in India's prisons. Return to a life of normalcy post incarceration is impossible. With the abolitionist movement gaining traction all over the world, this project evaluates these issues through the lens of Indian urbanism.

Alternative

This project investigates the current neighbourhood scenario and examines the potential of restorative justice interventions. The optimum location is studied through GIS. Societal study validates that the proposal can be embedded into existing schools, communities and neighbourhoods.



3.1 Current Mechanisms of Crime and Justice



Causes of Crime

Investigating the causes of major crimes in India revealed that exclusion from mainstream systems of income, education, backed by poverty, often led to a life of criminality.



Current Mechanism

Failures are different stages in the linear due process due to prejudice, loopholes and anti-poor sentiments through the judiciary

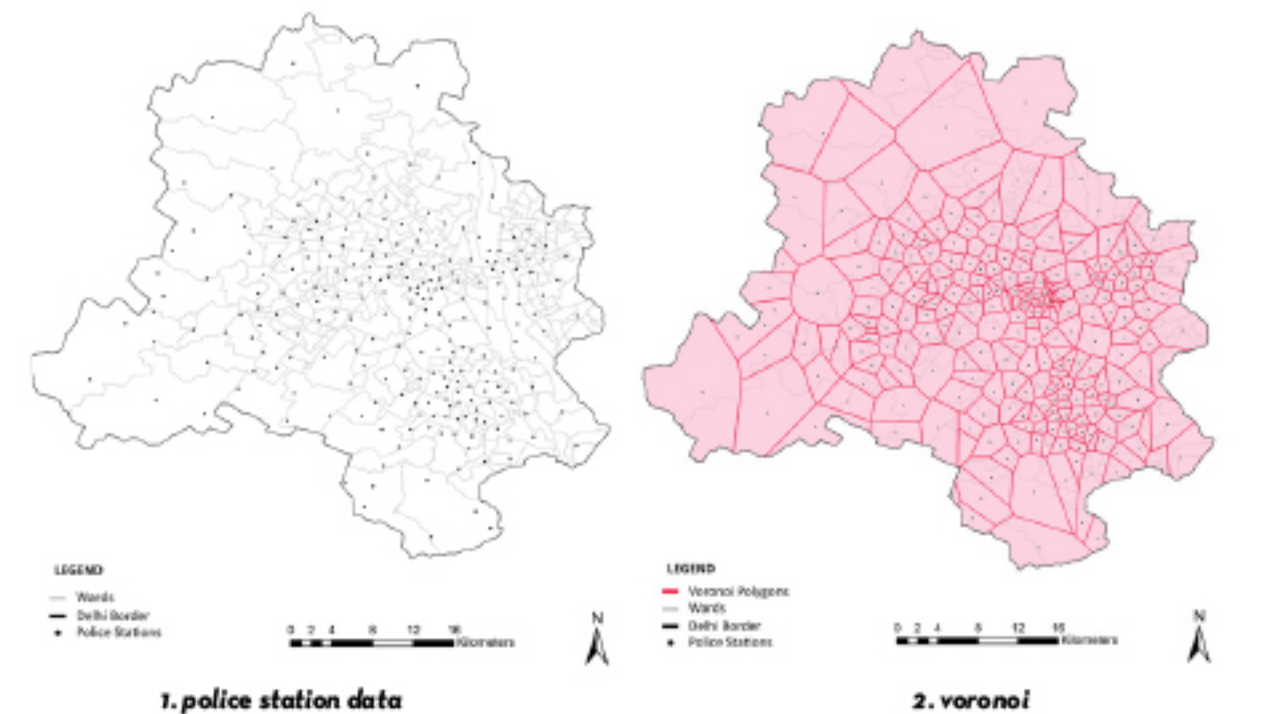


Proposed Mechanism

Community integrated reform, a decentralised system of justice with peacemaking embedded into existing community infrastructure

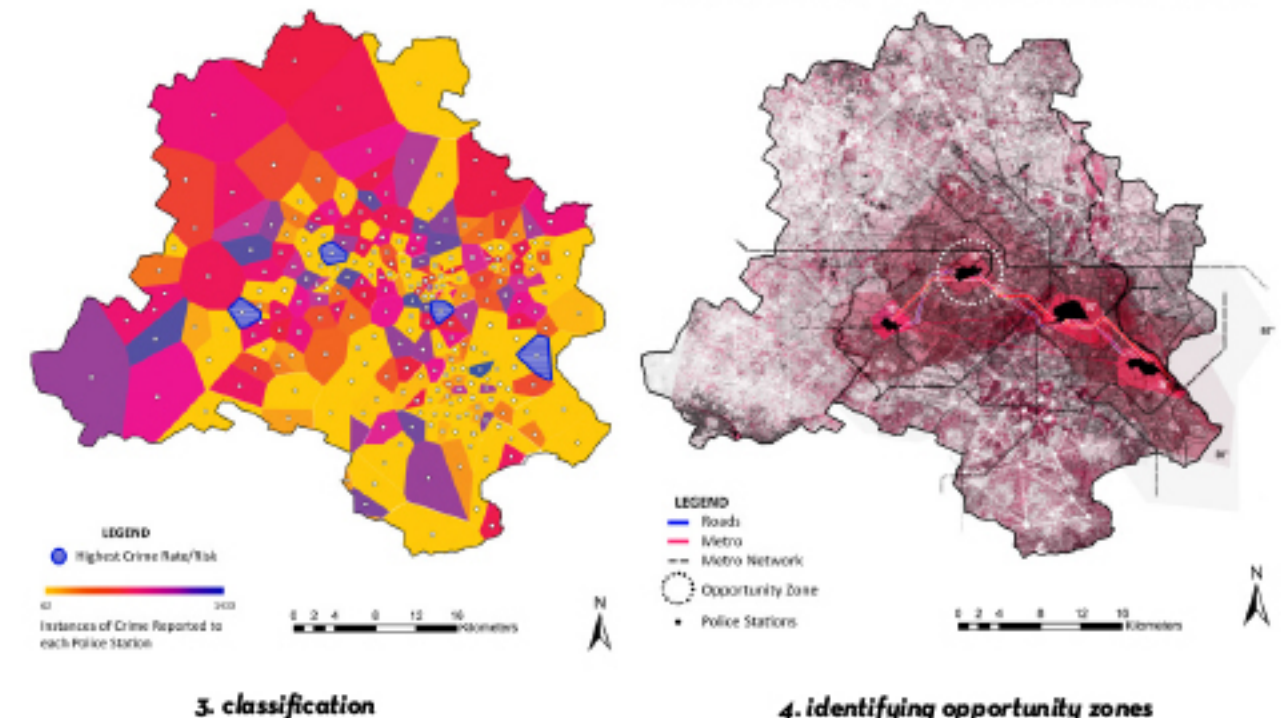
3.2 Site Identification

ANALYSIS OF NEW DELHI



1. police station data
Illustrates the locations of police stations distributed all over the wards of New Delhi. Using the data collected we can determine the jurisdictions of these stations.

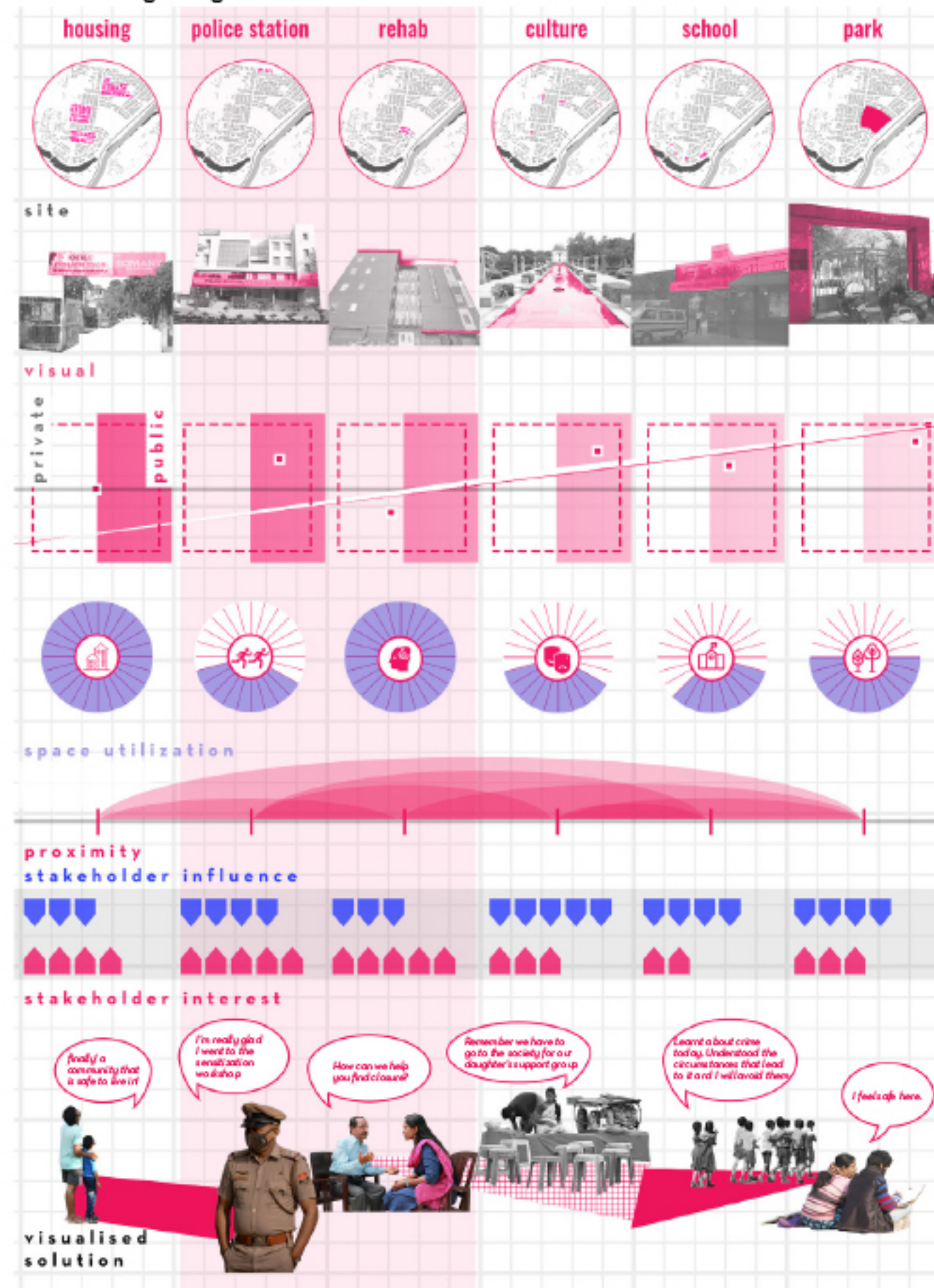
2. voronoi
Proximity determines which station is to be approached. Hence, we use the voronoi tessellation. all points located within an individual cell are closer to the police station within that cell than they are to any other



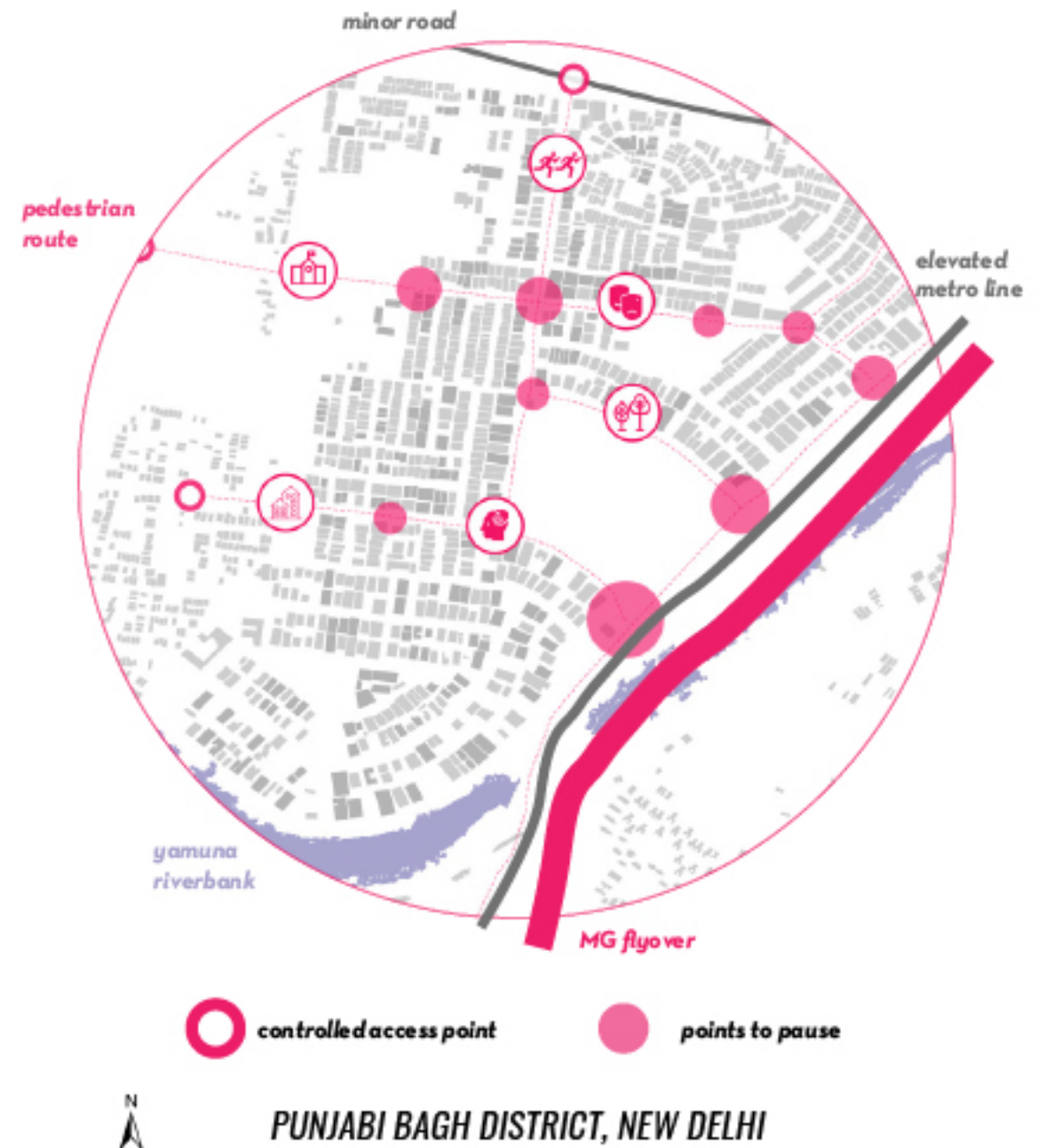
3. classification
Using the data associated with each police station we can classify these cells according to the frequency of crime reported at each station

4. identifying opportunity zones
Overlaying (3) with the land use land control map of New Delhi, we can identify sites where the intervention would be most effective (eg Punjabi Bagh, New Delhi)

3.3 Design Program



3.3 Zone Planning Analysis



Acceptance and support from one's community need to follow rehabilitation. This integration needs to be supported by an infrastructure that is hyper-localized - involving citizen's groups, making them direct contributors to the community's well being. Rural India incorporates peacemaking infrastructure of nyaay panchayats or "public justice courts" to establish community-based mediations often leading to solutions that uphold the civil liberties of all parties involved. Our cities do not have any such domestic legal framework, which is both the cause and the consequence of our lack of infrastructure to support this intervention.

Impact

For this program to be implemented successfully, work needs to be done with the laws and institutions that have been oppressing this community. Starting with smaller community-level interventions such as just courts and resident welfare associations can not only reduce the burden on the justice system, reserving the larger mechanisms for more serious offences but can also expedite the process of convict societal reintegration.